

« Opponents respect us more now. Earlier, a match against us was like a 50-50 affair but now they feel like they have to [take us seriously] »

SATWIK-CHIRAG

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With six individual titles, a rise to World No. 1, victory at the Asian Championships and the historic Asian Games gold medal, Satwiksairaj

Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty have had a near-perfect 2023. In a freewheeling discussion on *Sportstar Hangouts*, ahead of the 2024 season, Indian badminton's latest Khel Ratna winners discussed their no-fear temperament in finals, the joy of shutting down hostile crowds, secret of good communication as well as Chirag's penchant for orange bandanas and shirtless celebrations.

It's been a near perfect year. What do you think could have gone better?

Chirag: I think it's been a really good year. We played six individual finals and won five. Obviously, not the perfect year. A few misses but overall, we've ticked a lot of boxes. Like, winning the Asian Games gold (in men's doubles) and silver in the team event, becoming World No. 1, winning the Asian Championships and winning our first Super 1000 event.

Is there a difference in how your opponents treat you now? How do you deal with the increase in

expectations?

Satwik: Opponents respect us more now. Earlier, a match against us was like a 50-50 affair but now they feel like they have to [take us seriously]. Everyone watches our matches and has some strategy [to deal with us]. We don't take it to our head so much. We know what to do and don't want to think so much about what is happening behind [the courts]. We just want to focus on what is there in our hands. There are a lot of expectations, and a lot of things going on. People watch us. Everyone wants us to win a lot of tournaments. If we lose in the first round, there is banter. They're like, "How can they lose in the first round?"

Sometimes I feel it is good to lose in the first round. We had big failures this year but then after that we had big tournaments too. Before the Asian Games, we lost at the China Open in the first round. We played a very okay game. I didn't think we played badly or something, but it wasn't to our level. We sat with our coach, talked with our psychologist, made a plan and then, we were on to the Asian Games with full fire. Then, again, we had Singapore and Thailand where we lost in the second or first round and right after that we won the Indonesia Open. So, a few losses here and there helped us stay

on the right track.

What is your equation with crowds? There have been times where the crowd was against you, like when you were in China or Indonesia. Are you someone like Pat Cummins who said he enjoys the moment the crowd goes silent?

Chirag: Same. Exactly the same.

Satwik: We love playing against the crowd. Mostly when we are in Indonesia, they would be against us. When we were at the Indonesia Open and playing against an Indonesian pair, they would be booing us, and I said this is the time we had to prove ourselves. They will be commenting on our *Instagram* posts. That gives us a lot of motivation when someone is booing. They will be booing and inside I will be laughing. "*Tereko batata hu mai kya hu* (I'm going to tell you what I am)"

Now, people in the China Open actually cheered us. It's much more positive for us compared to before. When we come onto the court, we will get a loud cheer. But I still think if the crowd is against us, we play better. I don't want to be on the positive side of the crowd. They need to wake the animal inside me. Them booing me makes me not so relaxed; I'll want to play with fire.